

Cricket Basics

What is Cricket?

Cricket is a bat-and-ball game played between two teams of eleven players each, on a large oval field with a rectangular 22-yard pitch at its center. One team bats while the other bowls and fields, and the teams switch roles once an innings ends.

What is an Over?

An over consists of six legal deliveries bowled by one bowler from one end of the pitch. Once six balls have been bowled, the over is complete, the bowler changes ends or is replaced by a different bowler, and a new over begins from the opposite end of the pitch. A delivery that is a no-ball or a wide does not count toward the six, so an over with such deliveries can include more than six balls being bowled in total.

Batting and Scoring

The batting team tries to score runs by hitting the ball and running between the wickets, or by hitting boundaries for four or six runs. The bowling team tries to take wickets and restrict the number of runs scored per over.

Match Formats

Cricket is played in several match formats that differ mainly in how many overs each team bats for. A standard One Day International (ODI) match consists of 50 overs per side. Twenty20 (T20) matches are limited to 20 overs per side. Test matches, the longest format, have no over limit and are played over up to five days.

Key Roles

The bowler delivers the ball toward the batter at the other end of the pitch. The wicketkeeper stands behind the batter's wicket to catch deliveries the batter misses. Fielders are positioned around the field to stop runs and catch the ball to dismiss batters.